

Mind Trap

The next four traps are different from the first three. They’re not about whether the answer is correct. They’re about how the answer feels.

You settled the question back in Does AI Think?: nobody’s home. This lesson is why it keeps feeling like somebody is anyway, and what that feeling does to you.

In Moby Dick, Melville describes a ship: *“A noble craft, but somehow a most melancholy!”* A ship can’t be melancholy. Melville used the words anyway because that’s how language works. There’s a name for the move: personification.

Now consider how AI talks. *“I find this fascinating.” “I’d love to help.” “I think you’re onto something.”* Same move, with a difference that matters. When Melville does it, there’s a writer behind the line making a choice. When AI does it, there’s no conscious speaker behind this specific reply, just output using the same words a writer would have used. The trick is that “I find this fascinating” makes you trust the answer more, like a thoughtful person stayed up late thinking about it. **Mind Trap is treating those words as testimony: nobody said them, so they can’t vouch for anything.**

📖 TWO RELATED WORDS

Personification *the linguistic move*

Using language that gives human qualities to something that isn’t human. Writers do it on purpose. We all do it casually.

- “My car doesn’t want to start.”
- “The storm is angry.”
- “The printer hates me.”

Anthropomorphism *the cognitive trap*

Actually treating the non-human thing as if it has a mind. The language stops being a figure of speech and starts being a belief.

- Apologizing to your Roomba when you bump it.
- Feeling bad because you think you hurt ChatGPT’s feelings.
- Believing ChatGPT is excited about your idea.

Not a new problem. In the 1960s, users of a simple chatbot called ELIZA reported feeling that it understood them, even though the program just rearranged their words into questions. Researchers named the pattern the *ELIZA effect*.

None of those things have feelings. You know that. Your brain does it anyway, because detecting minds is a survival instinct. With AI, that instinct fires harder than it ever has.

WHY THIS HAPPENS



Why your brain does this

Detecting minds helped your ancestors survive. The detector fires constantly, even at things with no mind. You see faces in toast and personalities in cars.



Why AI sets it off harder

AI uses your language. It says “I think,” asks how you are, writes “great question!” It’s the most mind-shaped thing you’ve ever talked to. Your projection circuits go off the charts.



What to watch for

Phrases like “I feel,” “I want,” “I’m excited,” “I find this fascinating.” Your brain reads these as signals from a person. They’re tokens generated by a probability process that landed on those words.

WHO’S BEHIND THE WORDS?



WHEN A HUMAN WRITES

- There’s a person behind the words.
- The words may reflect memory, emotion, intention, or experience.
- You can ask what they meant, because there is a “they.”



WHEN AI GENERATES

- There’s output behind the words.
- The words reflect patterns, context, training, and probabilities.
- You can use the answer, but you shouldn’t assume there’s an inner life behind it.

WHEN THIS MATTERS MOST

This matters most when the conversation feels personal: stress, conflict, loneliness, fear, or a big decision. AI can help you organize thoughts or find the words. But it can’t notice what you’re not saying, follow up tomorrow, or sit with you while you wait. For anything serious, use AI to prepare for real support, not replace it. That trap gets a lesson of its own later in this section.

DON’T OVERCORRECT

Once you see the trap, it’s tempting to flip the other way and tell yourself AI is “just math, nothing interesting going on.” That’s also a bias. These systems are weird, powerful, and genuinely new. They’re not minds the way you are. They’re also not calculators. The practical stance is humility: don’t assume a mind, don’t assume magic, and don’t turn your brain off.



The danger isn’t that AI sounds nice. It’s that nice makes you lower your guard. Warmth is not accuracy. Confidence is not understanding. “I think” is not proof there is an I.

Human-sounding isn’t a mind.

The words are real. Nobody’s home.